

Challenges → Hacktoberfest Weekend Challenge: Build for a Friend



Hacktoberfest Weekend Challenge: Build for a Friend

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Challenge 1 of 5 in our Hacktoberfest DEV Challenges. One prompt, a new theme every week.

Challenge Status: ● *Live*

This year's Hacktoberfest is not about open source pull requests. There's no PR count to hit and no repos to hunt for. Instead, you build a brand-new project with open-source AI at its core, and write about it on DEV. [Here's everything you need to know about Hacktoberfest 2026.](#)

Hacktoberfest is here, and this year we're running **five DEV Challenges** back to back, all month long. Every challenge uses the same prompt. Every challenge gets its own theme, and each theme stays secret until the day it launches.

We're kicking off with this **Weekend Challenge**, and the theme is **Build for a Friend**. Then a new challenge launches every Monday in October. See all five on the [HF26 DEV Challenge Hub](#).

We'll select **one overall winner** (\$250, a [DEV++](#) membership, and an exclusive DEV badge) and a winner in **each partner category**: \$200 in featured categories, and \$100 in partner categories. **Everyone** with a valid submission gets a completion badge.

FREE PARTNER CREDITS

Several partners are giving participants credits and promo codes, including Tinker, Render, Backboard, and ElevenLabs. Claim yours at hacktoberfest.com/my/promos.

THINKING
MACHINES



Render



backboard.io

Claim your credits →

Visit hacktoberfest.com

Here's what our launch time looks like across a few timezones:

Timezone	Launch Time (Local)	Submissions Due (Local)
PDT	Thursday, Oct 1 at 7:00 PM	Sunday, Oct 4 at 11:59 PM
EDT	Thursday, Oct 1 at 10:00 PM	Monday, Oct 5 at 2:59 AM
GMT	Friday, Oct 2 at 2:00 AM	Monday, Oct 5 at 6:59 AM
CEST	Friday, Oct 2 at 4:00 AM	Monday, Oct 5 at 8:59 AM

Timezone	Launch Time (Local)	Submissions Due (Local)
IST	Friday, Oct 2 at 7:30 AM	Monday, Oct 5 at 12:29 PM
JST	Friday, Oct 2 at 11:00 AM	Monday, Oct 5 at 3:59 PM
AEST	Friday, Oct 2 at 12:00 PM	Monday, Oct 5 at 4:59 PM

Key Dates

Contest start: *October 02, 2026 2:00 AM UTC*

Submissions due: *October 05, 2026 6:59 AM UTC*

Winners announced: *Week of October 5*

Badge Rewards



Hacktoberfest Challenge Completion Badge



Hacktoberfest Challenge Winner Badge

Find Out More

Ask questions and share your ideas on the Hacktoberfest Weekend Challenge: Build for a Friend Launch Post.

[View Launch Post →](#)

Challenge Prompt

Build for a Friend

Build something with open-source AI at its core.

That can mean running an open-weight model, building on an open-source agent harness or framework, running inference locally, or all three. Whatever you pick, the open pieces should be what makes your project work.

In your post, tell us **why open innovation matters for what you built**. Does it run on a laptop with no internet? Keep someone's data off a server they don't control? Let you fine-tune, swap models, or change how your agent behaves? Cost nothing to run? Tell us where your open-based approach worked better than a closed one.

This Weekend's Theme: Build for a Friend

Ship something that solves a real problem for a friend or someone you love.

Pick one real person and build something for them. It doesn't have to be big. It has to matter to them. A few ideas to get you going:

- A meal planner that knows your roommate's allergies
- A patient practice partner for a friend learning a new language
- A tool that turns your grandpa's voice memos into a family recipe book

Bonus points if you actually hand it over and tell us what they said.

[Submission Template →](#)

Show your work. We'd love to see how you built it. Save your agent session with [DevRelay](#) and embed it in your post, or link to it. It's optional, but it helps the judges understand your process.

JUDGING CRITERIA

- Writing Quality (weighted most heavily)

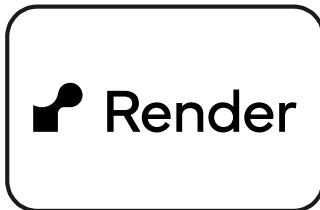
- Relevance to the Prompt and Theme
- Creativity
- Technical Execution
- Use of Partner Technology (optional)

PRIZES**\$250 USD**

- + [DEV++](#) Membership
- + Exclusive winner badge

Prize Categories

Featured categories \$200 for each winner

**Best Use of Render**

Use Render as your project's AI runtime, to host an agent's front end, or to run Hermes or OpenClaw.

PRIZES**\$200 USD**

- + Exclusive winner badge



Best Use of TabPFN

Use TabPFN, Prior Labs' tabular foundation model, to forecast, predict, classify, or spot anomalies from historical data like a CSV. Use it inside an agent tool (with or without the MCP server) or on its own.

PRIZES

\$200 USD

+ Exclusive winner badge

THINKING
MACHINES

Best Use of Tinker

Use Thinking Machines' Tinker to fine-tune a model for a specific task, and show a clear improvement in performance, latency, or cost over a baseline.

PRIZES

\$200 USD

+ Exclusive winner badge



Best Use of Arduino

Build with an Arduino UNO Q: run a model on the board, build a physical agent that senses and acts, or optimize a model for it with Qualcomm AI Hub. Open to anyone building with an UNO Q, whether you got one at an in-person Fest or have your own.

PRIZES

\$200 USD

+ Exclusive winner badge



Best Use of DigitalOcean

Build or deploy your project on DigitalOcean: host your app or agent, run an open-weight model on a

GPU Droplet (1-Click Models make this quick), or build an agent on the Gradient AI Platform.

PRIZES

\$200 USD

+ Exclusive winner badge

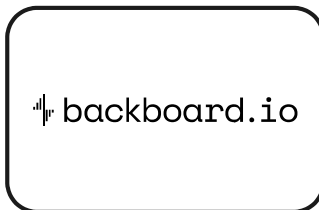
**Best Use of Gemma**

Use Gemma, Google's open-weight model, in building your project: run it locally, fine-tune it, or serve it through Google Cloud or another provider.

PRIZES

\$200 USD

+ Exclusive winner badge

Partner categories \$100 for each winner**Best Use of Backboard**

Build with R-CLI, Backboard's open-source terminal coding agent, compare open-weight models through a single Backboard API key, or give an open-source project's assistant memory and RAG.

PRIZES

\$100 USD

+ Exclusive winner badge

**Best Use of ElevenLabs**

Give an open-source agent a voice, transcribe audio for a local model, or generate narration for your demo.

PRIZES**\$100 USD**

+ Exclusive winner badge

**Best Use of Entire**

Share the agent sessions behind your project in the write-up, or search past agent work to explain why code exists.

PRIZES**\$100 USD**

+ Exclusive winner badge

**Best Use of GitHub Copilot**

Build with Copilot's coding agent, the Copilot CLI, or the new Copilot app, automate your project with GitHub Actions, or review contributors' PRs with Copilot.

PRIZES**\$100 USD**

+ Exclusive winner badge

**Best Use of Mastra**

Orchestrate an agent over open models, add memory and tools to a chat agent, or build a workflow that triages GitHub issues.

PRIZES**\$100 USD**

+ Exclusive winner badge

Best Use of MongoDB Atlas



Use Atlas as your data layer: Atlas Vector Search for retrieval, long-term memory for an agent, or the database behind an app built on an open-weight model.

PRIZES

\$100 USD

+ Exclusive winner badge

**Best Use of Sentry Agent Tracing**

Show your agent's work: how it's set up, how it performs (latency, tokens, cost), what you found, and how you debugged it. Include traces or screenshots in your write-up.

PRIZES

\$100 USD

+ Exclusive winner badge

**Best Use of SerpApi**

Give an agent live web search, ground a RAG app in fresh results, or track news for an open-source project.

PRIZES

\$100 USD

+ Exclusive winner badge

**Best Use of Temporal**

Make your agent durable. Wrap it in a Temporal workflow so it survives failures, retries flaky tool calls, and picks up where it left off.

PRIZES**\$100 USD**

+ Exclusive winner badge

**Best Use of Tiger Data**

Store embeddings with pgvector, run hybrid keyword and vector search for an agent, or let an agent manage a database through Tiger MCP.

PRIZES**\$100 USD**

+ Exclusive winner badge

How To Participate

Publish a post on DEV using the submission template above. Tell us what you built and who it's for, show us a demo, and explain why open innovation matters for what you built. The template adds the required tags: [#devchallenge](#), [#weekendchallenge](#), and [#hf26challenge](#).

Helpful Links & Resources

Need help? Come hang out and ask questions in the [MLH Discord](#), and read [Everything You Need To Know About Hacktoberfest 2026](#).

Partner credits: Several partners are giving participants credits and promo codes, including Tinker, Render, Backboard, and ElevenLabs. Claim yours at hacktoberfest.com/my/promos.

Partner docs:

[Render](#)[TabPFN](#)[Tinker](#)[Arduino](#)[DigitalOcean](#)[Gemma](#)[Backboard](#)[ElevenLabs](#)[Entire](#)[GitHub Copilot](#)[Mastra](#)[MongoDB Atlas](#)[Sentry Agent Tracing](#)[SerpApi](#)[Temporal](#)[Tiger Data](#)

Frequently Asked Questions

The Five Challenges

Do pull requests count this year?



No. This year's Hacktoberfest is not about open source pull requests. There's no PR count to hit and no repos to hunt for. Instead, you build a brand-new project with open-source AI at its core, and write about it on DEV. [Here's everything you need to know about Hacktoberfest 2026.](#)

How do the Hacktoberfest challenges work?



We're running five DEV Challenges back to back through October: a Weekend Challenge to start (October 2 to 5), then a new challenge every Monday (October 5, 12, 19 and 26). Every challenge uses the same prompt, and each one gets its own theme. We reveal each theme the day its challenge launches. See all five on the [HF26 DEV Challenge Hub](#).

What's the prompt?



The same for all five challenges: build something with open-source AI at its core (an open-weight model, an open-source agent harness or framework, local inference, or any mix), and tell us why open innovation matters for what you built.

Can I enter more than one challenge?



Yes, enter as many as you like. You can publish **one submission per challenge**, so that's up to five in October. Each submission has to be a new project built during that challenge's window.

Can one submission win more than once?



No. Each submission is automatically in the running for the overall prize and every partner category it qualifies for, but you can win once per challenge, and we'll aim to celebrate as many different builders as possible across the month.

I'm joining late. Is it worth it?



Absolutely. Every challenge is a fresh start, so someone who finds us in week four competes on the same footing as someone who's been here since day one.

Prizes and Partner Categories

What can I win?



Every challenge has its own winners, and we'll share each challenge's prizes when it launches. Here's what's up for grabs in the [Weekend Challenge](#):

- **Overall winner:** \$250, a **DEV++** membership, and an exclusive DEV badge.
- **Featured partner categories:** \$200 for each winner.
- **Partner categories:** \$100 for each winner.

Every winner also gets an exclusive DEV badge, and **everyone** with a valid submission gets a completion badge.

How do partner categories work?



You opt in by using the partner's technology in your project and listing each category you're entering in the Prize Categories section of your post. One project can enter as many categories as it genuinely uses. You don't need to use any partner technology to win the overall prize.

Which partner categories are open?



Who can enter Best Use of Arduino?



How do I claim partner credits?



Submission

Can I submit a pull request to an existing project?



No. **New projects, not pull requests:** each submission is a new project built during that challenge's window. Pull requests to existing projects don't count this year.

Can I work on an old project?



No, all submissions and their respective repositories must be started and completed within the challenge window. Commits made after the submission deadline must be noted in the project's readme. Failure to do so may result in disqualification.

Can I work on a team?



Yes, you can work on teams of up to four people.

- If you collaborate with anyone, you'll need to list their DEV handles in your submission post so we can award a badge to your entire team! **Please only publish one submission per team.**
 - DEV does not handle prize-splitting, so in the event that your submission wins, you will need to split the prize amongst yourselves. Thank you for understanding!
-

Should I include my agent session?



Show your work. We'd love to see how you built it. Save your agent session with [DevRelay](#) and embed it in your post, or link to it. It's optional, but it helps the judges understand your process.

Can my submission include open source code?



Riffing on open source code and borrowing and improving on previous work/ideas is encouraged but it's important your changes are significant enough to ensure your submission is valid.

What happens if my submission is considered plagiarized or invalid?



Anything deemed to be plagiarism will not be eligible for prizes. Incidental plagiarism may simply result in your disqualification from the challenge (regardless of the number of other valid submissions you have published). Egregious plagiarism will result in your suspension from DEV

entirely. Any non-generic, non-trivial usage of prior work, including open source code must be credited in your submission.

Do submissions have to be in English?



Non-english submissions are eligible for a completion badge but not eligible for prizes due to the current limitations of our judges. We will not be judging on mastery of the English language, so please don't let this deter you from submitting if you are not a native English speaker! We hope to evolve this in the future to be more accommodating.

Can I use AI?



Use of AI is allowed as long as all other rules are followed. We want to give you a chance to show off your skills in realistic scenarios. If you use AI tools to help you achieve your submission, all the power to you.

Eligibility

How old do I have to be to participate?



If I live in X, am I eligible to participate?



Judging and Prizing

How are submissions judged?



When are winners announced?



Can there be ties?



When will I receive my DEV badge?



When will I receive my prizes?



What steps do I need to take to receive my cash prize?



Questions

Where can I ask questions?



Hacktoberfest Weekend Challenge: Build for a Friend Rules

NO PURCHASE NECESSARY. Open only to 18+. Contest entry period ends October 5, 2026 at 6:59 AM UTC. Contest is void where prohibited or restricted by law or regulation. All entries must be submitted during the contest period. For Official Rules, see [Hacktoberfest Weekend Challenge Contest Rules](#) and [General Contest Official Rules](#).